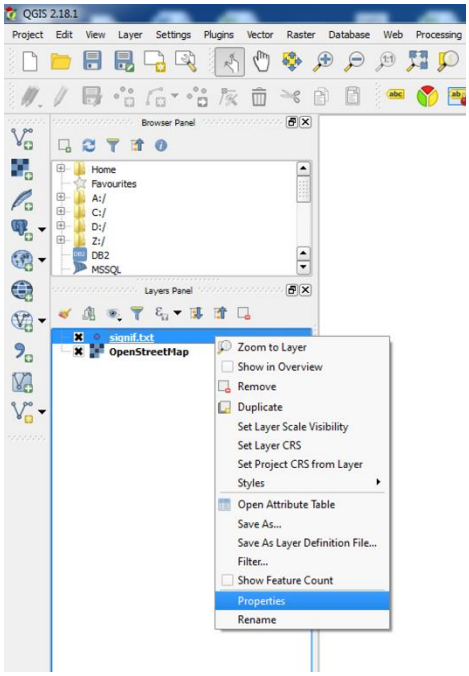
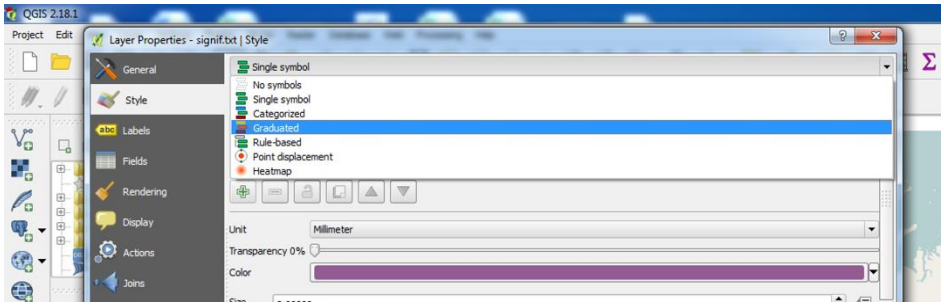
Change style of displayed data

1. Right click on a layer in the layers panel



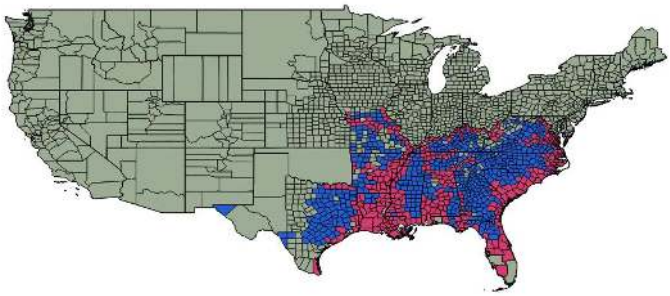
2. Select “Properties”
3. In the new window, click “Style” on the left side of the screen. This is where you will be able to select options for how your variables from your excel chart are displayed.



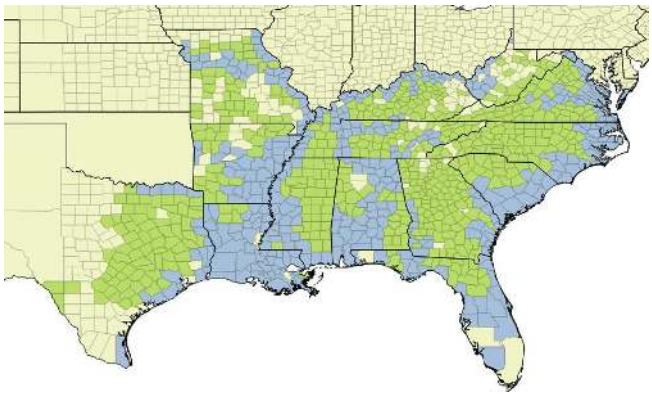


The default is **"Single Symbol".** It just shows the shape file completely filled.

"Categorized" shows different colors for different categories within the variable. For example, the variable has a 0 for if a county does not have access to water and a 1 if it does. These are two distinct categories that could be displayed with two different colors. To automatically add categories, click the "classify" button. The first image below shows the result.



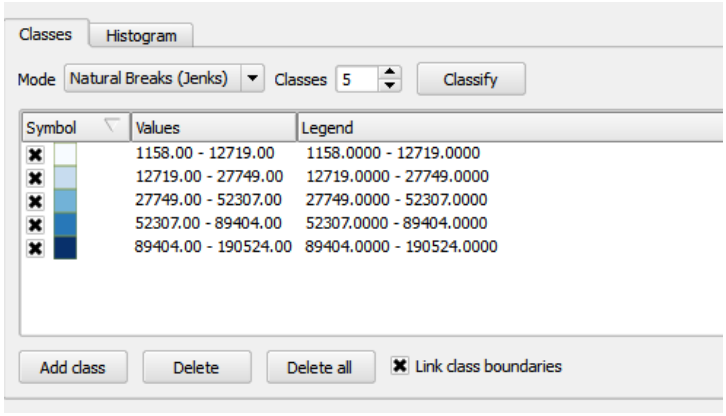
Sometimes the default colors are not the most informative. You can quickly change any color in the Layers Panel. Simply right click on the box where the color appears. For even more options, select the "Edit Symbol" button.



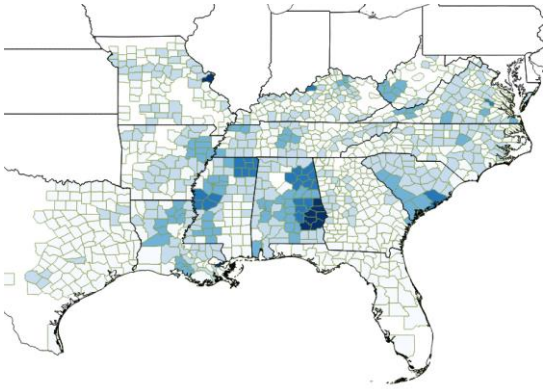
Not only does this look cleaner, but it is also more informative because green now represents land and blue represents water.

A third option for visualizing your variables is the **"Graduated"** option. This is useful for a continuous variable. For example, total population has many different values, so it is better to display with gradual colors than all different colors for every single number.

You have many options for which range of numbers each color will represent. These are all under the "Classes" tab. I find Natural Breaks (Jenks) to be best for showing clear variation, but the way you choose to define each category will depend on your data.



For automatic classifications, select the mode you would like, how many classes you would like it to be broken into and hit “classify”.



This is the result. The darkest colors represent the counties with the highest populations.